



ALLIANCE PROTOCOLS

The Architecture of Staying

WHY DELIBERATE DESIGN HELPS RELATIONSHIPS
THAT LOVE ALONE CAN'T HOLD

We are an alliance.

Built for precision. Designed for connection.

by David Hamilton and Zhongming Shi · Companion Volume · Version 1.2

A NOTE BEFORE YOU START

Every couple in this book is a composite, with names and details changed, stitched together from patterns common enough that you'll recognise pieces of your own week in them. None of them is anyone's real marriage. The patterns are the point, not the people. Two things are ours: 'The Third Voice' is our own story, told by David with a few details changed, and the Prologue couple, Mara and Theo, are invented but their fight is based on an argument of ours (the Third Voice says how).

This book sits beside the Alliance Protocols Operating Manual. It tells the stories behind the tools; it doesn't replace them. Where this book names a pattern, the Manual gives you the tool. Think of it this way: this book is the why, the Manual is the reference, the Field Kit is a folder of cards with its map on the fridge, and the free Field App is for when it's actually happening.

This book is for couples who are safe with each other. If you are afraid of your partner, or of anyone in your home, it is not for this: please get outside help first. The Help Lines are on the last page of the Field Kit and at allianceprotocols.com/help.

Ⓜ IF YOU'RE NOT SAFE — HELP LINES

This book is about couples who are frustrated, drifting, or stuck — not about anyone who is afraid. If you're afraid of your partner, being threatened, or not free to say no, stop here: these tools are not for this. Get outside help.

Immediate danger: your local emergency number (999 UK/SG · 911 US · 000 AU · 112 EU)

US: National Domestic Violence Hotline 1-800-799-7233 (text START to 88788) · 988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline (call/text 988)

UK: National Domestic Abuse Helpline (Refuge) 0808 2000 247 · Samaritans 116 123

Australia: 1800RESPECT 1800 737 732 · Lifeline 13 11 14

Singapore: National Anti-Violence & Sexual Harassment Helpline 1800 777 0000 · SOS 1767

LGBTQ+-affirming: US: Trevor Project 1-866-488-7386 (under 25) · LGBT National Hotline 1-888-843-4564 · UK: Switchboard LGBT+ 0800 0119 100 · Australia: QLife 1800 184 527 · Singapore: Oogachaga (oogachaga.com)

Elsewhere: your local emergency number or national helpline.

If you're worried about your own behaviour: UK: Respect Phoneline 0808 8024040 · Australia: Men's Referral Service 1300 766 491 · Singapore: PAVE 6555 0390 (office hours)

Men experiencing abuse (UK): Men's Advice Line 0808 8010327

Singapore, more: AWARE Women's Helpline 1800 777 5555 · if you can't speak, SMS 70999 (police)

EU: 116 016 (helpline for women experiencing violence, where available)

If someone checks your phone or books, keep this somewhere private; you can find the Help Lines at allianceprotocols.com/help.



PROLOGUE

The Kitchen at 9.40pm

The kitchen could be anyone's.

Mara is standing at the sink with her hands in water that's gone cold, and she can't remember what she's supposed to be doing with them.

Behind her, Theo is still talking. Not loudly. That's almost the worst part — if he were shouting, she'd know where she stood. Instead his voice has that flat, reasonable register he gets when he thinks he's being patient, which somehow lands harder than shouting ever did.

"I'm not saying it's a big deal," he says. "I'm saying you said you'd call the plumber, and it's been eleven days."

It isn't about the plumber. They both know it isn't about the plumber. But neither of them can find the actual thing underneath it, so they keep circling the plumber like it's the only solid ground in the room.

Forty minutes ago they were fine. They'd eaten dinner, split a bottle of wine, laughed about something Theo's manager said in a meeting, and Theo had already posted the card for her sister's birthday. Then Theo mentioned the sink drain, Mara said something clipped about being tired of being the one who remembers things, and now — this. A kitchen. Cold water. A conversation neither of them chose to have, going somewhere neither of them wants it to go, as if it had decided on its own.

"You always do this," Theo says.

"Do what?" Her own voice has gone flat and reasonable too. She can hear it.

"Turn it into me being the bad guy for asking a normal question."

"I'm not turning it into anything. I'm just *tired*, Theo."

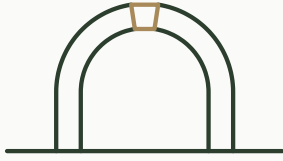
And there it is — the word that ends the conversation without ending the fight. Mara goes quiet. Theo takes the quiet as confirmation he was right to feel unheard, and pushes once more, gently, which is the wrong kind of gentle right

now. Mara says she needs a minute. Theo says fine, in the tone that means it isn't. She goes to the bedroom. He stays in the kitchen, staring at a drain that, to be fair, really has been slow for eleven days.

Neither of them is a bad partner. Neither of them did anything a stranger reading a transcript would call cruel. And yet here they are, on a Tuesday night, two rooms and a long way apart, over a plumber neither of them has called.

You could call this a communication problem, in the vague, poster-in-a-therapist's-waiting-room sense of that phrase. They already communicate, technically: words came out of both their mouths, in the correct order, forming complete sentences. What neither of them had was a map for what was happening between them, and so both of them improvised, and the improvisation made it worse.

This book is about what a map would have shown them.



CHAPTER I

The Myth of “If We Just Love Each Other Enough”

Love is the reason, not the method.

Here is a sentence that sounds wise and is almost completely useless:
relationships take work.

Everyone says it. Nobody explains what the work actually is. It's the relationship equivalent of being told to “eat healthier”: true, unobjectionable, and no help at all at eight in the evening when you're standing in front of an open fridge with no plan.

Most people go into a serious relationship with exactly one theory: if the love is real enough, the rest will sort itself out. Good intentions, deep feeling, the right person. Surely that covers it. And for a while, it does. Early on, novelty does a huge amount of the work for you. You're curious about each other by default. You *want* to ask how the day went. Small generosity costs nothing because the whole thing still feels a little bit like a gift you can't quite believe you got.

Then time passes, and novelty stops doing the work.

Nothing has gone wrong; that's what novelty does. Novelty is a startup grant, not a salary, and every long relationship eventually has to work out what to live on once the grant is spent. The couples who don't figure this out don't usually fall apart in one dramatic rupture. They drift. Drift sounds passive, like something that happens *to* a relationship. It isn't. It's a thousand small, forgivable non-decisions. Skip one real conversation because you're tired. Let one small hurt go unnamed because raising it feels disproportionate. Answer “how are you” with “fine” because the honest answer would take longer than either of you has right now. None of these is a betrayal. Added up over a few years of ordinary weeks, they're how two people who genuinely love each other end up feeling like colleagues who share a mortgage.

Mara and Theo didn't stop loving each other somewhere between the wine and the sink. What happened is smaller and stranger than that, and it's worth slowing down for. A low-stakes comment about *the plumber* hit an assumption

neither of them had looked at: *I'm the one who remembers things, always, and it's exhausting, and I've never said that out loud.* (Not quite always: the birthday card, the car and the Sunday calls are Theo's, and he does them without being asked. But that isn't how it feels from the sink.) That set off something in both their bodies, and it made them worse at listening at exactly the moment they needed to listen.

Neither of them sat down and designed that evening. That's the trouble. Nobody designs it, so it designs itself, and left alone it tends to slide towards distance, because distance takes no choosing and closeness does.

The idea under this book is plain, and it took us years of watching these tools hold, fail and get rebuilt to believe it: **a relationship that runs entirely on feeling, with nothing agreed underneath it, isn't a purer or more romantic relationship. It's a relationship with nothing to fall back on.**

In our experience, romance lasts longer when something is holding it up. Everyone drifts; two busy people sharing a life always will. What matters is whether you notice it early, and fix it before it becomes distance nobody can name.

Taking love seriously looks like that: noticing the slow drain on the second day, not the eleventh.

GO DEEPER Manual Ch 2 (The Short Version), Ch 13 (Micro-Repairs, home of the 2% habit) and Ch 1 (Why a Relationship Needs a Plan)